million volumes were printed in Europe. By contrast, in the previous thousand years only about eleven million volumes were hand-copied.[65] By 1600, all kinds of fringe people – heretics, revolutionaries, proto-scientists – could disseminate their writings much more rapidly, widely and easily than ever before.

In the history of information networks, the print revolution of early modern Europe is usually hailed as a moment of triumph, breaking the stranglehold that the Catholic Church had maintained over the European information network. Allegedly, by allowing people to exchange information much more freely than before, it led to the scientific revolution. There is a grain of truth in this. Without print, it would certainly have been much harder for Copernicus, Galileo and their colleagues to develop and spread their ideas.

But print wasn't the root cause of the scientific revolution. The only thing the printing press did was to faithfully reproduce texts. The machine had no ability to come up with any new ideas of its own. Those who connect print to science assume that the mere act of producing and spreading more information inevitably leads people to the truth. In fact, print allowed the rapid spread not only of scientific facts but also of religious fantasies, fake news and conspiracy theories. Perhaps the most notorious example of the latter was the belief in a worldwide conspiracy of satanic witches, which led to the witch-hunt craze that engulfed early modern Europe.[66]

Belief in magic and in witches has characterised human societies on all continents and in all eras, but different societies imagined witches and reacted to them in very different ways. Some societies believed that witches controlled spirits, talked with the dead and predicted the future; others imagined that witches stole cattle and located hidden treasure. In one community witches were thought to cause disease, blight cornfields and concoct love potions, while in another community they supposedly entered houses at night, performed household chores and stole milk. In some locales witches were thought to be mostly female, while in others they were generally imagined to be male. Some cultures were terrified of witches and persecuted them violently, but others tolerated or even honoured them. Finally, there were societies on every continent and in every era that gave witches little importance.[67]

For most of the Middle Ages, most European societies belonged to the latter category and were not overly concerned about witches. The medieval